While this is true, it must not be forgotten that in that very essay, when Bhagat Singh is a condemned man awaiting the gallows, he is writing about his father's move in 1917 from Banga Village in Lyallpur to Lahore. This was a time when he was ten years old. He was all set to go to high school. Despite all the influences of the big city to which he would have been open, he describes how '[i]t was through my father's teachings that I aspired to devote my life to the cause of freedom'. [8] But perhaps more than anything else, what sets him apart from his family, Moffat proceeds to correctly recount, is 'his stern condemnation' as a prisoner on the brink of execution in 1930 'of the mercy plea submitted to the Viceroy of India by Kishan Singh, [9] demanding his son be saved from the gallows'. Moffat is not wrong to draw attention to how Bhagat Singh upbraided his father 'in a public letter and chastises [him] for weakness'. [10] Indeed, Bhagat Singh has no qualms about telling his father how 'in the political field my views have always differed with those of yours. I have always been acting independently without having cared for your approval or disapproval'. [11]

One cannot, however, overlook the formative influence that Bhagat Singh's family—in particular his uncles and his grandfather—had on his inner development as a young man who took on the British Raj. That influence has been there even if we bear in mind the strong words of the letter Bhagat Singh wrote to his father shortly before his death. It is his last letter to his father. Despite his exasperation at his father, he tells him that 'I know you have devoted your life to the cause of Indian independence . . .'. It is true that Bhagat Singh is 'astounded' and indeed 'quite perplexed' at his father's intervention to save his life. He fights hard to control his outrage, pointing out that 'I fear I might overlook the ordinary principles of etiquette, and my language may become a little harsh'. But this is only because he and his fellow condemned prisoners 'have been pursuing a definite policy in this trial'. Against this background, Bhagat Singh was bound to have chided his father with the words that 'I feel as though I have been stabbed in the back'. He was bound to have described this sort of action to his father as being 'nothing short of treachery'. While the words used are indeed scathing coming from a son to his father, Bhagat Singh